



PHOTO / STEVE ROSENTHAL

One of William Rawn's standouts: Seiji Ozawa Hall at Tanglewood.

Architecture

Rawn builds connections through tradition

By Robert Campbell
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The joy of being an architect is the agelessness. Just when your doctor and lawyer friends are starting to think about retirement, your own career is taking off. For an architect, life begins at 50. Philip Johnson is 89 this year and still going strong. Frank Lloyd Wright accomplished a third of his life's work after 80.

That's why the new exhibit on the work of Boston architect William Rawn at Roger Williams University in Rhode Island is intriguing. It offers us a chance to be present at the creation.

Rawn started his firm 12 years ago. Before 50, he'd already won a shelf of prizes for good architecture, and even gained his 15 minutes of fame as the hero of Tracy Kidder's best seller "House." And this is a second career: Once Rawn was a

successful young lawyer and university administrator. Still, as architects go, he's a new kid.

For me, two buildings stand out among Rawn's achievements: the Back of the Hill housing in Boston and Seiji Ozawa Hall at Tanglewood. They could hardly be more different. Back of the Hill is several blocks of affordable row houses in Mission Hill. Ozawa Hall is a concert auditorium set among the summer estates of the Berkshires. One client was the Bricklayers and Laborers' Union. The other was the Boston Symphony Orchestra.

That span tells you a lot about Rawn, who thinks the main purpose of architecture is to bring together different kinds of people. In a statement with this exhibit, he writes: "I believe in cities - and indeed any places - that reflect the values of diversity, accessibility and participation that are so fundamental to the

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American democracy."

Rawn likes streets, and believes in the kinds of buildings that support the life of the street: "that place where all citizens are invited and entitled to meet, to jostle, to confront, and to embrace."

Also on view here are Rawn's row houses for the Charlestown Navy Yard, a multiple prize-winner; his dorms at Bates College in Maine; a tiny performance pavilion in Lowell; parking garages for Rochester,

N.Y.; and planning studies for Rochester and Charlottesville, Va. All are displayed in superb mural-size color photos. The only flaw in this handsome show is the lack of showing the creative process. You don't get to see the early sketches, the study models or the false starts that preceded the final design.

If there's one word for this architect - and it's a word that puts him in the mainstream of this downsizing decade - it's "responsible." Rawn doesn't try to thrill you with novelty. He also doesn't try to win your love by tweaking sentimental memories. His work grows directly from the traditions of the past, to be sure, but it's never nostalgic. Rawn just assumes there are a lot of good ideas in tradition, and an architect would be a fool not to check them out. In that sense, he's still a lawyer, mining for useful precedent. He's the opposite of avant-garde. He's looking to make connections, not sever them. The last thing he wants to be is clever or fashionable.

Take Back of the Hill. You can't miss the influence of South End bowfronts. But they're used for their appropriate virtues, not for their ability to evoke nostalgia. Like the planners of the old South End, Rawn is trying to create an affordable, durable, humanly scaled neighborhood that suits Boston's climate and culture. Like those planners, he's trying to make private houses that gather to shape public streets. If he plays some old familiar themes - bay windows, stoops, ornamental brickwork - it's because they get the job done.

► "William Rawn Architects: Ideas of City, Celebrations of Place" runs through March 27 at the School of Architecture, Roger Williams University, Bristol, R.I. (for directions, phone 401-253-1040). Rawn is scheduled to give a public lecture May 3 at 7:30 p.m. at the Museum of Fine Arts, Boston. It will be part of the MFA's spring series on the architecture of Boston.

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